Moderating effect of cultural differences on the association between social media use and mental health outcomes in adolescents: A cross-cultural comparison study

Gordeseli et al. 2024

1 Introduction

Context

- Adolescent mental health is linked to Social Media (SM)

Gap

- Cultural factors are **rarely** examined as underlying mechanisms

Aim

- To investigate the association between **SM-Use** and **anxiety/depression**, moderated by horizontal/vertical individualism and collectivism

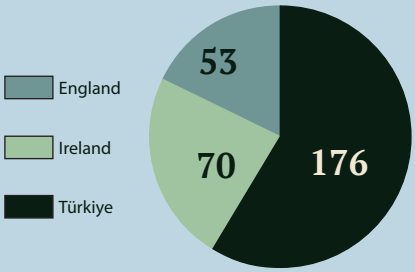
2 Key Concepts

Horizontal Individualism (HI)	Valuing autonomy and uniqueness without status-seeking
Vertical Individualism (VI)	Valuing autonomy, competition, and status attainment.
Collectivism (HC/VC)	Valuing interdependence and group harmony (Horizontal) or hierarchy/duty (Vertical)

3 Methodology

Method

CROSS SECTIONAL STUDY conducted between January 2020 and July 2021



Number of Participants

Measure Tools

CULTURE : INDCOL - 16 Scale

MENTAL HEALTH

Anxiety : GAD - 7

Depression: PHQ - 9

SOCIAL MEDIA

Self - reported hours

Data Anaysis

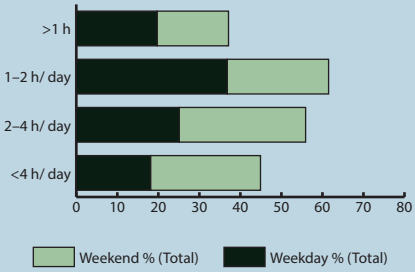
Multiple Imputation and **Hierarchical Regression** were used to control for demographics and explore interaction

4 Results

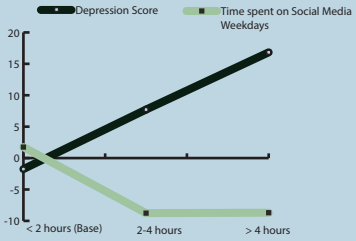
Social Media Usage Pattern

Usage Trends
higher during weekend compared to weekdays

Weekend vs. Weekday
More than a quarter of the total sample (26.8%) spent over 4 hours daily on SM during weekends, compared to 18.1% on weekdays



Mental Health Patterns & Outcomes



Turkish Participants:

- higher risk for depression on weekdays (>4 h)
- anxiety on weekends (>2 h)

English/Irish Participants:

- most affected on weekends
- >4 hours of SM-Use higher anxiety and depression

5 Discussion

Individualism as Risk:

- **High VI** increases susceptibility to depression
- stems from status-seeking, upward social comparison, and the pressure to project an "idealized" self online

Protective Factors:

- in the Turkish context, the most protective factor against depression was the **combination of low HI** and **minimal SM-Use**.

Study Limitations:

- Data may be influenced by **recall bias** due to self-reporting
- the cross-sectional design prevents establishing a direct cause-and-effect relationship.

6 Conclussion

Critical Indicators:

- Spending >4 hours daily on SM is a significant indicator of **potential mental health risks** in middle adolescents

Cultural Importance:

- Interventions must be **cultuarally sensitive**
- Individualistic traits significantly shape how SM impacts mental health.

Action:

- there is a high prevalence of undetected mental health issues
- **school-based screening** and **detection strategies** are essential for supporting at-risk youth.

7 Reference

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